What is the Bible?

We can now answer the question what the Bible is. On the surface the question appears simple but the answers one gets lead us to see how important it is. What the Bible is, is an important question often asked but also variously answered.

The British Times Newspaper 1996 refers to the Bible as the world best seller that no one reader reads. This conception can be further stretched to the point that the Bible is viewed as the humanity's greatest treasure. It is the greatest literary work ever written. The greatness of the Bible can be judged by its influence on humanity throughout history.

The word Bible relates to Greek Τὰ βιβλία (*ta biblia)* which translates as "books". Basically we understand the Bible as a collection of writings. Therefore, we are often more acquainted with the definition of the Bible as a library of books. Soon we realize this definition is inadequate since the Bible is not simply any collection of writings.

The Bible is God's written communication to humanity. These are a collection of writings that contain God's message to people. Thus comprehensively we can talk of the Bible as pluralistic text, made up of many parts with many divergent views about God and his relations with the world.

This understanding of the Bible will help us for instance deal with frequent questions such as: How is the Bible the word of God? And do Christians have only one Bible?

The first question is directly relevant to the current discussion. The statement needs to be broadened to include the human element. The Bible is both the word of God and human word. It is the word of God in terms of the divine message it communicates. The divine communication to humans is expressed in human language which is determined in human circumstances and situations. The Bible, for example, written under Jewish culture predominately uses this cultural setting to pass its message. Hence the Bible becomes predominately male in its applications. It is for example the woman who fast sins. Paul tells the women not to speak in assemblies. The combination of both the human and the divine elements is best mirrored in the doctrine of incarnation where Jesus combines both the divine and human nature.

The Bible takes after the nature of Jesus who was both divine and human. Jesus was God but to make himself more comprehensible he took upon himself our nature. The Bible in a like manner is God's instrument in expressing the divine will which can only best be understood through our languages.

It is therefore important when we read the Bible to always seek the message (meaning) behind the words used. We may ask for example what does it mean God rested on the Seventh day? The reading of the Bible must thus of necessity be a critical process. It is important to examine how we read and understand what we read in the Bible.

Therefore, one of the primary purposes for reading the Bible is to know what God expects of us as his stewards. God intends us to study his word but how to go about it is always a challenge. Key to the study of the Bible is its interpretation. There exists a legend that, "when the Holy One, blessed be He, gave the Torah to Israel, he gave it only in form of wheat, for us to make flour from it or flax, to make a garment from it." God depends on the community to fulfill the biblical meaning.

HOW TO READ THE BIBLE

Broadly speaking approaches to the Bible can be categorized into two, that is, academic and non academic approach. When we talk of academic, we are referring to the scholarly use of the Bible. Here we have in mind approaches like historical critical and literary critical approaches, while non academic readings are at times labeled spiritual or devotional approaches. However, it must be bore in mind that these two broad approaches are not necessarily mutually exclusive of each other. Both, for example, imply a critical reading of the Bible. Any meaningful reading of the Bible must be a critical reading. Again both are concerned with exposing the meaning of the text. The difference is on the emphasis.

The non academic approach is more concerned with the impact of the text on the reader. When a Pastor prepares his sermon his or her ultimate concern is what the audience learns from the text. Therefore, what is given Promise is the appropriation of the text.

Generally, even the non academic reading of the Bible is diverse in nature. Roughly we may categorize these readings into four groups: Historical, Inspirational, Literary and Theological.

Historical Approach

The historical reading of the Bible is also referred as the literal approach. Many people assume the chronological order of the events in the Bible. They take for granted that the manner the events are reported in the Bible is how they actually occurred. They read the Bible as a book of history. When the Bible says God created the earth for seven days it is literally so.

Such a reading misses the point, since the authors of the biblical text were not concerned with reporting things the way they actually happened but rather with their significance. They preferred to go with the meaning behind the events. This is the reason for instance we have in the same Bible two apparent contradictory stories of creation: Gen. 1:1 – 2:4a and 2:4b-25. "One would read a contradiction between the first and the second accounts of creation. When did God create human beings for example

as the first or the last creature? Again how do you conceive God creating light on the first day and only later on the fourth day create the sources of light (such as moon and stars). Is it as often thought by some that God can afford to do whatever he likes? It has also been argued even of recent times that the Bible and science are incompatible.

These difficulties can best be resolved if we understand the intention of the biblical writers. These writers did not set out to write history for its own sake but rather the significance of it. The writer gives the importance or the meanings of the happenings?

Therefore, the creation story for example is not about creation itself, i.e., how God created, what he used, how long he took etc. It is about meanings. God is the author of all things in existence. He has shared this creative power with us human beings.

The effect of historical reading is that many people either despise the Bible as contradictory in nature or as fallacy, i.e., not telling the truth. On the contrary, the Bible is concerned with the ultimate truth, i.e., that which we can rely on for our salvation. Jesus becomes the ultimate truth that the Bible is concerned about (Mt 22:16; Joh14:6).

Therefore, the best way to conceive the Bible is that it is a story of salvation. Stories are generally told to convey meanings.

Inspirational Approach

This is another popular way in which many read the Bible. It is a motivational approach. One reads the Bible by situating the self in the state of the people of the biblical times. We so often come across expressions such as: "if the Lord did it then he can do it now." Ps. 23 are popularly sung by many to illicit such a reading. However, the greatest challenge with such a reading is that it can be very selective. It creates attention only to particular texts in the Bible, and in extreme cases those texts have been clearly marked in colours. The end effect is that it makes the reading of the Bible uncritical. We just assume and receive everything hook line and sinker. It is important to always bare in mind that the whole Bible speaks to us.

LITERARY APPROACH

Many a times students tell me that they read the Bible for entertainment just to enjoy the stories. In other words, they are reading the Bible like literature i.e. like a book of William Shakespeare or Chinua Achebe. No one would object that the Bible is a piece of literature. In fact, it is often termed the greatest literary work ever written. But the underlining question is: Is the Bible like any other literature?

The Bible is a religious literature. It is a confessional document. The Bible is an embodiment of a people's faith.

THEOLOGICAL APPROACH

We are here reminded of the word theology which comes from the two Greek words: *Theos*, meaning God and *Logos* for word or science. So basically it means the science of God. Theological approach is concerned with reading for meaning. The reader seeks to understand the meaning of certain things from the Bible. For example what does Bible say about issues like war, homosexuality, abortion etc. The question that arises out of this quest is whether the Bible has all the answers to all human questions.

The answer is indeed "Yes" but with a nuance. The Bible is basically about historical people and historical events. It is often said history repeats itself through circumstances that might be different. Though our situation may differ from those of biblical time, however, in the Bible find the parameters in which we can respond to our issues.

Theological reading, however, is not without its danger. Such an approach is open to business. History of the Bible informs us that the use of the Bible has been both positive and negative. We know that evil such as slavery, apartheid and women oppression were supported on the basis of bias reading of the Bible.

We have so far outlined four readings of the Bible with their critique. It is apparent that there is need for a way forward. Hence the question is always asked: What is the best way to read the Bible? The best way must be a profitable reading of the Bible. It means therefore it must be a critical reading.

A critique reading must begin with our disposition. We ought to approach the Bible with an open eye, ears, heart and mind. This is an attitude open to learning. The opposite of this is twofold: the assumption that we already know everything about the Bible or that the Bible is too hard to comprehend. Great many fall under the former. But one teacher who set to test his students on the Bible knowledge asked where the famous saying "God helps those who help themselves is found in Bible." Of course various biblical texts were recited but none was correct.

Again we must read the Bible contextually. Many readers jump from verse to verse that suits them. Very often these verses are read out of context. The most important principle in interpretation is the context. There are generally many contexts of the Bible like sociological, literary and immediate context. The present or the immediate context of the text (what comes before and after) suffices for ordinary reading of the Bible. The knowledge of the context helps to avoid error and difficulties.

The reading becomes more profitable when the Bible is read with others in the community especially with those who belong to different aspirations than ours. It safeguards against our biases when we listen to different voices. This approach situates the Bible to its original setting which is the community.